Combat in the Hollow World system is intended to be dynamic and brutal, with potential for epic, anime-esque setpieces, quick and brutal beatdowns, and intense duels alike. It accomplishes this with a system of tight actions and active as well as passive defenses.

Combat happens in rounds, a period consisting of roughly six seconds of in-game time. Players and monsters take turns over the course of the round, which ends when no other participants in the combat have remaining actions. To illustrate the concepts in the rest of the chapter, we will turn to our stalwart characters, the fighter Bobbin and the rogue Dmitri.

The structure of a round

Each participant in a given combat receives seven actions at the beginning of each round. Certain abilities or conditions, like the Haste spell or the Stunned condition, can increase or decrease this number. These actions can be spent to attack, move, cast spells, interact with the environment, or perform any number of other actions.

At the beginning of a combat, the participants each make an initiative check. This determines the turn order for the remainder of the combat. On each of their turns, a participant may do two things: step 5 feet, and take one of their actions for the round. A character with no actions remaining is spent, and cannot take any.

At the beginning of their fateful duel, Bobbin and Dmitri each roll initiative. To do so, they roll a d20 and add their Intuition and Dexterity scores to the total. Dmitri has a Dexterity of 4 and an Intuition of 1, for a total initiative modifier of 5, while Bobbin's Intuition is 2 and their Dexterity is 1, for a total of 3. Unfortunately for Dmitri, he only rolled a 7 on the d20 for a total of 12, and Bobbin rolled a 10 for a total of 13. Looks like Bobbin is going first!

Reactions

A number of abilities are reactions, meaning that they can only be performed in response to a particular trigger. To react to a trigger, a character spends one of their remaining actions for the round, and thus can't react if they're spent.

Bobbin and Dmitri are both prepared for their fight, weapons in hand, so for Bobbin's first turn they Charge at Dmitri, spending a Stamina point Combine a Stride and a Strike with their longsword into a single action. As a reaction to the attack, Dmitri Dodges, rolling 18 on a Mobility check to try to avoid the blow. Bobbin rolls a total of 17 to hit, beating Dmitri's Armor Class of 15, but failing to beat his Mobility check. Thus the attack falls on empty air as Dmitri deftly steps to the side. Now each character has spent one action for the round, and Bobbin has spent a single Stamina point.

This example includes the Stride, Strike, and Dodge actions, as well as a combination. Here they are formatted for you:

Strike	1 Action
Stam: 0	Repeat
Make an attack with a weapon you wield. This is a Strength or Dexterity attack vs. the target's Armor Class using the weapon's range, damage type, and any other modifiers. *Hit:* 1[W]+Strength or Dexterity damage. This scales to 2[W]+Strength or Dexterity at Tier 2 and 3[W]+Strength or Dexterity at Tier 3.	

Stride	1 Action
Stam: 0	Movement, Repeat
Move up to your speed	

Dodge	Reaction
Stam: 0	Trigger: You are targeted by an attack targeting Armor Class or Reflex and are not Immobilized.
You avoid an incoming attack by jumping out of the way. Make a Mobility check. You may use the result of this check in place of your Armor Class or Reflex against the triggering attack. After the attack is resolved, Step. If there are no open spaces into which you can step, the Mobility check automatically fails to protect you.	

Block	Reaction
Stam: 0	Trigger: You are hit by an attack targeting Armor Class
You intercept your enemy's weapon with your own. Reduce the damage taken by 1[W]+your weapon's Block value. Additional effects that occur on a hit do not occur. This scales to 2[W]+Block at tier 2 and 3[W]+Block at tier 3. If your blocking weapon has a Block die, use that in place of its weapon die.	

Parry	Reaction
Stam: 0	Trigger: You are hit by an attack targeting Armor Class
You deftly maneuver your weapon to deflect your enemy's attack. Make an attack roll against the attacking enemy, adding your weapon's Parry bonus to the total. If the total is greater than your attacker's attack roll, the attack does zero damage and additional effects that occur on a hit do not occur.	

Steel	Reaction
Stam: 0	Trigger: You are targeted by an attack targeting Fortitude or Will and are conscious.
You ready yourself to weather an incoming effect. Make a Determination check. You may use the result of this check in place of your Fortitude or Will against the triggering attack. If you resist the attack, you gain a +2 bonus to the next check you make this round.	

Guard	1 Action
Stam: 0	Repeat
You take a defensive posture, ready to react to anything. You gain a +1 bonus to all of your defenses for the remainder of the round.	

Step	Special
Stam: 0	Movement
You move 5 feet (1 square/hex). This movement does not trigger any reactions from other actors. You may Step as a free action. If you do so, your action this turn may not have the Movement trait.	

Critical Hits

If at any point an attack exceeds the targeted defense by 10 or more, the attack becomes a critical hit. Roll your damage dice twice and add double your damage modifier to the total - this is the damage dealt.

Certain abilities will alter this. For example, a Rogue with the basic Lethality talent will land a critical hit when their attack exceeds the defense by 9 or more, and the next Lethality talent adds 1d6 to their critical hit damage.

Combinations

You can expend Stamina to Combine two actions into one. This doesn't let you perform more than one action per turn, but it does let you do more with that action. We've already seen one example of a Combination in the combat described above, where Bobbin the Fighter combined a Stride and a Strike to both move and attack Dmitri in one action.

You can also combine an action with itself if it has the Repeat trait. This lets you, for example, Combine Stride and Stride to sprint, or Strike and Strike to attack twice in a single turn.

Reactions can also be combined with other actions. For example, you can combine Block and Strike or Parry and Strike to riposte your attacker.

Certain talents will alter the costs involved in combining actions. For example, the Mobile Channeler talent allows a caster to Combine the Channel action and the Stride action at no Stamina cost. Certain conditions like Dazed prohibit you from combining any actions, so be careful!

Actions	**Reactions**
Strike	Block
Stride	Parry
Cast a spell	Dodge
Interact	Opportunistic Strike
Guard	Shield (spell)
Take Cover	Steel